

THROUGH THE WIRE

On October 23, 2002, West was in a California recording studio producing music for Beanie Sigel, Peedi Crakk, and The Black Eyed Peas. After leaving the studio at around 3 a.m. in his rented Lexus, he had a near-fatal crash when he had fallen asleep at the wheel.[1] He was taken to Cedars-Sinai Medical Center, mentioned in the song as “the same hospital where Biggie Smalls died”, and had his jaw wired to his face in reconstructive surgery. Two weeks after being admitted to the hospital, he recorded the song at the Record Plant Studios with his jaw still wired shut.[2][3] Consequence recalls that West started rapping the lyrics to the song three days after the crash.[4]

The song’s title refers to the wires used to hold his broken jaw together, as well as being a play on the song “Through the Fire”, which it samples. When asked about how the incident changed his music, West stated:

Well, the only thing this accident’s is saying is, “I am about to hand you the world, just know at any given time I can take it away from you.” To nearly lose your life, to nearly lose your mouth, your voice, your whole face, as a rapper...and I had to be on TV! My face looks crazy to me now... But I have to just thank God for the situation that I am in... “Through The Wire” is the worst thing that could’ve possibly happened to me, and now it’s obviously the best thing. Look how it exploded![5]

The song originally appeared on West’s mixtape Get Well Soon... as “Through the Wire (Still Standing)” where his wired jaw was incredibly noticeable, and also including an outro that is sampled from Elton John’s hit “I’m Still Standing”, before being re-recorded and released as the first single from The College Dropout in late 2003.[6][7][8] Although he initially had trouble convincing Roc-A-Fella Records executives to let him make his own album as a rapper, he was able to change their minds after the song’s release.[9]



“Through the Wire” was inspired by the 2002 car crash, and West has provided a comedic account of his difficult recovery. West samples a pitch-shifted and sped up version of Chaka Khan’s 1985 single “Through the Fire”.[10] Coodie, one of the music video’s directors, reported that Khan wouldn’t initially allow the sample to be cleared until the video was shown to her son and he told Khan about it, leading to the sample being cleared about two weeks later.[11] Khan later expressed her love for the track, calling West a “sweet-heart, truly adorable” and the way he used the sample “so clever”. However, in June 2019, Khan criticized West’s unorthodox, highly pitchshifted use of the sample, calling it “stupid”. Also,



The New York Times’ Kelefa Sanneh described him as “a wounded hero beating the odds”, and it “gave him a chance to prove that he was the exception to the rule that producers can’t rap.”[7] Stylus Magazine called it “a poignant, pop-culture-packed account of Kanye’s near-fatal run-in with Chaka Khan”.[17] By rapping with his jaw sewed up, The Source noted that West used “the element of surprise to his advantage”.[18] HipHopDX listed the track as one of “the classics that created” the album’s hype,[19] and Pitchfork Media stated it was “chock-full-of-clever”.[20] Vibe magazine wrote that “West’s sideways approach to music making stands out” on the track and the “raw, teeth-clenching narrative falls in line with his gutwrenching soul beats.”[21]

As West’s debut single, “Through the Wire” has been recognized as a jump-start for his career after the song was played on MTV. Director for the music video, Coodie, would say, “The night of when he did the ‘Through the Wire’ premiere party at 40-40 Club, that was the night that was like, ‘Oh shit.’ That’s when Def Jam started recognizing him. Everybody was blown away by the video and it just kept building from there. Then after that show on SOBs on October 1st, he was bonafide. He was popping. It was full-on Kanye season.” Consequence would say to Complex on The College Dropout’s 10th anniversary, “The accident wound up being a blessing for him. Whatever diction issues he had, he came through with a super clear voice.

“Through the Wire” debuted at number ninety-four on the Billboard Hot 100 and peaked at number fifteen for five weeks. It remained on the chart for twenty-one weeks.[28] It performed better on the urban contemporary charts, reaching number eight on the Hot R&B/Hip-Hop Singles & Tracks and number four on the Hot Rap Tracks.[29] In the United Kingdom, it debuted at number nine on the UK Singles Chart where it peaked for two weeks and exited the chart after nine weeks. The track charted lower in other European countries, where it reached the top thirty in Ireland, Sweden, and the Netherlands, the top fifty in Belgium and Switzerland, and number sixty-one in Germany. The maximum peak time in those countries lasted one week.

